

# Every project has a name, an owner, a number and a limit.

Not a cost-cutting programme. The spending control that every other budget line already has, applied to the one where the decisions are made daily by people who never see the invoice.



## Named

One identifier per project, across every resource it touches.



## Owned

A named person who signs off the budget and answers the alert.



## Measured

A cost per customer or per transaction, refreshed daily.



## Limited

A ceiling that binds before the invoice does.

## WHERE WE ARE TODAY

# The bill arrives before the explanation

Three gaps, and none of them is a reporting problem — reports we have.



### No owner on the change

When the number moves, naming who caused it takes days. Often it is never established at all.



### The data arrives too late

Billing lands a day or two behind, so every cost alert reports what already happened.



### Nothing stops a runaway

No quota, no ceiling, no approval gate. The first hard limit is the invoice.

## We are not alone in this

# 4 in 5

need a day or more to trace an AI cost spike to its source

# 52%

have no clear owner for AI cost at all

# 78%

of FinOps practices now sit in the CTO/CIO organization

State of FinOps 2026; Harness / Sapio 2026 (vendor-sponsored).

**The consequence:** unexplained variance gets padded into next year's budget, so poor visibility quietly inflates the plan as well as the bill.

## STEP ONE — SEE IT

# One number per project, with an owner on it

Two things have to be true: the cost can be traced to someone, and the project is priced whole.

### Trace it to an owner

- 1 Tag at creation**  
Five tags, enforced by policy. Untagged means undeployed.
- 2 Allocate the spend**  
Target under 5% unallocated, reported weekly.
- 3 Show teams their own numbers**  
Four to six weeks before anything is charged.
- 4 Divide by the unit**  
Cost per customer, per order, per conversation.

### Price the project whole

An AI feature is quoted at its token cost. It runs on a stack that bills every month regardless.

- Model / tokens**  
the line everyone quotes
- Compute, databases, cache**  
app services, SQL, Redis, queues
- Storage, network, observability**  
backups, egress, log ingestion

*Every layer bills whether or not the model is called.*

**One ApplicationID across every resource a project touches.** The review then sees a single number with a single owner — and the model's share becomes a ratio anyone can argue with, rather than the headline.

## STEP TWO — CONTROL IT

# Two moments, and only one of them is cheap

At design, changing a cost is a conversation. After deployment, it is a migration.

### AT DESIGN — SHIFT LEFT

FinOps sits in the design and intake conversation, understanding what the project needs before the architecture is set.

- **Priced options**  
Two or three costed before one is chosen.
- **A cost target**  
Recorded beside the latency and availability targets.
- **Enforced in the pipeline**  
Tagging and budget rules as policy, not paperwork.

### AT RUNTIME — GUARDRAILS

Controls that act on spend already running, ordered by how fast each one takes effect.

- **Quotas and rate limits**  
Seconds. The only control that stops spend in progress.
- **Alerts routed to owners**  
Minutes on usage data. Never a page on a budget number.
- **Budget thresholds**  
Notify, review, gate — against the elapsed month.

*“A cost alert cannot save you from a runaway job — by the time the billing data moves, the money is spent.”*

WHAT WE ARE ASKING FOR

# Ninety days, and two decisions today

Weeks 1-4

## Name it

Tag taxonomy published and enforced. An owner recorded for every application above a spend floor.

Weeks 5-8

## See it

One number per project, showback to every team, and cost in the design review.

Weeks 9-12

## Hold it

Quotas on the largest workloads, alerts routed to owners, monthly review with finance.

How we will know it is working

|                           |                       |
|---------------------------|-----------------------|
| Allocation coverage       | under 5%              |
| Time to attribute a spike | hours, not days       |
| Cost per unit             | trending, per project |

Decisions needed today

1. Who owns the tagging standard, and by when?
2. Are we willing to have a limit that blocks?

No new headcount and no platform purchase in this plan. A tooling decision comes later, and only if allocation cannot be fixed at source.